reporter tracking the government told me. The more liberal and transparent UPA-II media set-up had led to a near-anarchic situation where ministers would often speak out in conflicting voices. By tightly controlling the information and restricting media access, Modi, it seems, wants to recapture the executive space that the Manmohan Singh government might have ceded to agenda-setting prime-time television, but the fear remains that a limited news can also promote a more opaque governance. The belief is: less news = less chaos. But let's also not forget: more opacity = less freedom.

He's even stopped the tradition of having a large contingent of journalists accompanying the prime minister on foreign visits. I had enjoyed travelling with Vajpayee on quite a few occasions. Yes, the air travel was a bit of a luxury—you were plied with plenty of free booze and chocolates, all, of course, at the tax payer's expense. Air India would put its best foot forward on the prime minister's plane—the hospitality was matchless. I must confess to having seen a few of my fellow journalists do almost everything but report on these trips. One of them had to be literally pulled away once from a night club in Paris in a drunken stupor before the police was called in.

But for serious, professional journalists the long flights also gave us a chance to interact with key government officials and build relationships in an informal setting. It gave us an insight into a prime minister's functioning beyond the forbidding corridors of South Block. Vajpayee once even advised us on which were the best places to eat in New York! Modi, though, is not a bon vivant—the pracharak in him has little time for discovering the many charms of New York. 'Why do we need to oblige the media?' was the cryptic question he posed to an official who tried to make a pitch for the journalists. Perhaps Modi has a point—it is time to end the junket culture that bedevils a section of the Indian media.

It's not just the media—the judiciary has also been put on notice. By fast-tracking the National Judicial Commission Bill that seeks to restore the primacy of the executive over judicial appointments, Modi is attempting to redraw the balance of power between the judiciary and the executive. The